PILOT FEEDBACK REVIEW · NOVEMBER 2026

Listening to students

What the pilot schools told us in four weeks, and what has already changed because of it.



nextstepuni

Prepared for PwC · Pilot programme 2026–27

Every quotation in this deck is a real, anonymous message from the in-app feedback inbox.

THE QUESTION

“How does gathering feedback this year benefit the platform for September 2027?”

The short answer: the loop is already running. Students write to us from inside the app, we read every message, and the fix is usually live within the week. Four weeks of the stripped-back pilot produced this.

41
student messages
Real, anonymous, in-app

4
pilot schools
3 workshop days in October

16
changes already live
Each traceable to a message

3
days, median
From message to live app

Counts: in-app feedback inbox, 18 Aug to 4 Nov 2026, test entries removed. Shipping dates from the production release log.

HOW IT WORKS

The feedback loop, as built

1

Listen

A feedback button on every page of the app. One tap, type, send. Plus three in-person workshop days in the schools.

2

Triage

Every message lands in a review inbox and moves through New, Reviewing, Planned and Fixed. Nothing is deleted.

3

Ship

Fixes go straight to the live app. No release train, no waiting for a term to end. Most land the same week.

4

Tell them

A What's New note in the app shows students the change they asked for, so the next message comes sooner.

Feedback is anonymous by design. A message carries no name, email or school. Only the platform administrator can read the inbox, and the only thing that can be edited is its review status.

Source: anonymousFeedback review workflow and Firestore security rules, production.

WHERE IT CAME FROM

Three workshop days, four schools, one inbox

Date	School	Accounts created	Messages sent
Mon 12 Oct	Marino College	60	16
Thu 15 Oct	St Joseph's	60	3
Fri 16 Oct	O'Connell's and Larkin Community College	112	10
October workshops		**232**	**29**

A further 12 messages arrived outside the workshops, from students using the app at home, up to 4 November.

What students chose to send

32 Feature ideas

5 Something else

4 Something is broken

Four in five messages were ideas, not complaints. Students were telling us what they wanted next.

Accounts created: production sign-up logs for each workshop day. Messages: feedback inbox, by date sent, test entries removed.

IN THEIR OWN WORDS

What students wrote

“my study time keeps getting deleted after i log it for some reason”

12 Oct · iPad app

“The island feature is sooooo slowwwww pls fix it.”

12 Oct · Marino workshop

“id like if the timer didnt shut off when on other apps so i could study (with notes on my ipad) and log my time simultaneously... maybe a miniplayer or something”

12 Oct · iPad app

“at the end of a session you could add a button that says ‘Keep going?’ and add a few more minutes to keep going with your session”

5 Oct · at home

“I would like to see the points bars where I’m currently at and what my goal points are”

12 Oct · Marino workshop

“I want LCVP as a subject” · “Are you able to add polish as a language” · “Add Romanian”

12 to 22 Oct · 15 messages on subjects

“i cant change my exam date”

16 Oct · O’Connell’s and Larkin workshop

“I would like questions on the study topic at the end of the study sessions to test me on”

16 Oct · O’Connell’s and Larkin workshop

“you’re the first dev team that seems to actually listen to their users, and I’m eager to help as much as I can.”

15 Oct · St Joseph’s workshop

Verbatim from the feedback inbox, spelling as written. Longer messages are trimmed with an ellipsis; nothing is reworded.

THEMES

Six things students kept asking for

15 messages

My subject isn’t here

LCVP, Polish, Romanian, Portuguese, Ukrainian, Russian, Chinese, LCPE and the LCA courses.

Shipped 18 Oct

7 messages

Test me on what I studied

A short quiz after a session, flashcards, a test per subject to know where to start, answering before seeing the answer.

Shipped 27 and 31 Oct

6 messages

The island

Slow on school iPads, no way to delete a misplaced tile, and more to do with the points earned by studying.

Shipped 13 and 14 Oct

5 messages

The study timer

Lost study time, a Keep going button, a stopwatch mode, a timer that survives switching apps, a Lock Screen timer.

Shipped 14 to 18 Oct

5 messages

Show me my progress

Current points against goal points, a view of everything set up at onboarding, changing the exam date, seeing classmates.

Shipped 14 to 18 Oct

4 messages

Getting in, and the rest

A reset link that didn’t work, studying live with friends, a red background, a doubt about the study planner.

1 shipped · 3 in review

Some messages asked for two things, so the theme counts add to 42 across 41 messages.

The study timer

A student wrote	Now in the live app	Live on	Days
“my study time keeps getting deleted after i log it for some reason” · 12 Oct	A running session survives an iPad tab reload, and a finished session waits in an outbox until the server confirms it was saved. Reproduced, fixed, tested.	14 Oct	**2**
“the timer didnt shut off when on other apps… maybe a miniplayer” · 12 Oct, and “minimise the timer” · 19 Oct	A minimised timer that keeps counting across every tool in the app and while the student is in another app, with pause, resume and tap to return.	15 Oct	**3**
“add a button that says ‘Keep going?’” and a stopwatch mode · 5 Oct	Keep going adds 5, 10 or 15 minutes to the same session when the countdown ends, with a small bonus for finishing. An open-ended mode counts up until the student stops.	15 Oct	**10**
“having to fully unlock [the iPad] to check how much time is left detracts from its purpose” · 15 Oct	The timer on the iPhone and iPad Lock Screen as a Live Activity, and a notification when time is up. Asked once, in context, never on launch.	18 Oct	**3**

Days = calendar days from the message to the change being live for every student. Dates from the production release log.

The island and My Progress

A student wrote	Now in the live app	Live on	Days
“The island feature is sooooo slowwwww pls fix it.” “The island mode is a bit slow on Ipad.” “The game is really slow and laggy.” · 12 Oct, three students	The island now moves as one layer and repaints once per drag instead of 119 times. Artwork rebuilt for school iPads: 24 MB of tiles became 2 MB, and the work done per drag dropped from 2.25 s to 0.14 s.	13 Oct	1
“add a ‘delete’ option on the build your own island, i have made a mistake on my island and i cannot delete it” · 12 Oct, two students	Tiles can be removed and swapped. A mistake no longer costs the student the points they studied for.	14 Oct	2
“I would like to see the points bars where I’m currently at and what my goal points are” · 12 Oct	My Progress shows current CAO points against goal points, and the onboarding grades step explains how points work at every level.	14 Oct	2
“i widsh there was view for all the stuff I did on onboarding” · 12 Oct	A Your setup page: everything chosen at onboarding in one place, editable, reachable from the sidebar and on iPad.	14 Oct	2

Island performance figures measured in Chrome with a 4x CPU throttle on the same scripted drag, before and after.

Subjects, setup and getting in

A student wrote	Now in the live app	Live on	Days
“I want LCVP as a subject.” “Are you able to add polish as a language.” “Add Romanian.” Plus Portuguese, Ukrainian, Russian, Chinese, LCPE and the LCA courses · 15 messages, 5 to 22 Oct	Every subject the State Examinations Commission examines is now in onboarding: every language, PE, and LCVP graded on its own Distinction, Merit, Pass scale. Foundation level Maths and Irish. The full LCA course list. Search finds a subject by its other names.	18 Oct	6
“i cant change my exam date” · 16 Oct	The exam date is editable on Your setup, so a student who picked the wrong year is not stuck with it.	18 Oct	2
“your password reset link doesn’t work for me” · 12 Oct	Reproduced: asking for a second reset email cancelled the first. The app now says only the newest link works, waits before resending, and a dead link explains why and sends a fresh one from the same page.	15 Oct	3
Observed at Marino, 12 Oct: students struggling to get into new accounts on the school iPads	A failed sign-in now says why, in plain words, instead of “invalid email or password” for everything. Sign-up suggests a fix when a school email is mistyped. Failure reasons are recorded anonymously so each workshop shows what actually went wrong.	15 Oct	3

Days for the subjects row count from the first message on 12 Oct; the last of the fifteen arrived four days after the change went live.

THEY SAID, WE SHIPPED · 4 OF 4

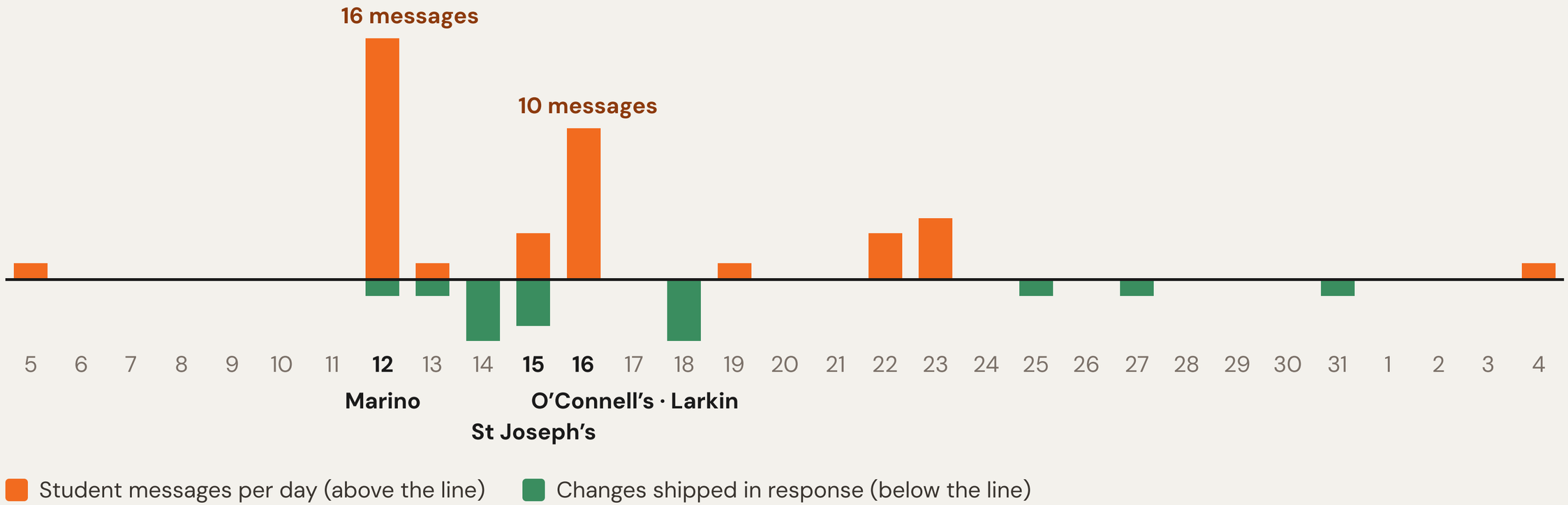
Test me on what I studied

A student wrote	Now in the live app	Live on	Days
“after every session we get short test to help us and see if we have improved.” “questions on the study topic at the end of the study sessions to test me on.” · 16 Oct, two students, and again 23 Oct	After a session is saved, four short real exam questions on the topics studied. The student answers, reveals the official marking scheme, and ticks what the examiner would have given. Results feed a spaced-repetition review deck. A quiz never costs study time, and there is an off switch.	27 Oct	**11**
“I would like to answer questions before seeing the answer” · 23 Oct	Past-paper questions can be attempted before the scheme is revealed, so a student commits to an answer first.	31 Oct	**8**
“I would love if there were more questions … for geography” · 16 Oct	The Geography revision deck was completed for every paper from 2010 to 2026, roughly doubling it.	25 Oct	**9**
“Could add flashcards to make studying and revision before an exam easier” · 16 Oct	The flashcard deck built from official marking schemes, more than 42,000 cards across every subject, is now named as flashcards where students look for it, and the end-of-session quiz feeds it.	18 Oct	**2**

Every question and every answer in these features comes from a State Examinations Commission paper or marking scheme, with its source shown.

CADENCE

Messages in, changes out, day by day



5 October to 4 November 2026. One earlier message from 18 August, before the pilot, is not shown.

STILL ON THE LIST

What we have not built yet, and why

“a quiz or a test for each subject so that people know where to start”

23 Oct

In design

Irish oral: “Speaking into the app, seeing it getting better and better each time.”

23 Oct

In design

“THE ABILITY TO STUDY LIVE!” with classmates

18 Aug

Planned

Keep me signed in on this device, for shared school iPads

Observed at every workshop

Next

“a section accessible for college students because i would love to continue using this app after secondary”

12 Oct

Graduates keep access · decision pending

“input your own custom subjects or topics that you want to study”

5 Oct

Parked · every SEC subject now listed

“I wish we could look at other people progress too”

4 Nov

Islands shareable · progress needs a privacy call

“the quite capybara, maybe once you click on it, there could be other animal options”

12 Oct

Parked, fondly

Every message keeps its place in the inbox with a status. Nothing is closed without a reason.

THE STRIPPED-BACK PILOT, AND THE FULL APP

Students are already asking for the part they haven’t seen

WHAT THE PILOT SCHOOLS HAVE HAD

Three surfaces

- Study sessions and the timer
- The Journey island, earned by studying
- The Learning Lab modules

No exam practice. Four weeks, 41 messages.

→

WHAT THEY ASKED FOR

Exam practice

- “a short test after every session”
- “flashcards for revision before an exam”
- “a test for each subject so people know where to start”
- “answer questions before seeing the answer”
- “more questions for geography”

→

ALREADY BUILT, IN THE FULL APP

Ten more surfaces

- Every SEC paper, 1995 to 2026, with its scheme
- 42,000+ scheme-backed flashcards, self-marked
- Questions by topic, as printed
- Answer Architect, Definition Drill, Diagram Vault, Marking Lens
- Coursework Studio, Oral Trainer

Every question and card in the full app comes from a State Examinations Commission paper or marking scheme and names its source.

SEPTEMBER 2027

What a full year of the full app gives the next cohort

NOV TO DEC 2026

Full app in the four pilot schools

Exam practice switched on for students who have already asked for it. Second feedback round while the loop is warm.

JAN TO FEB 2027

Mocks

The past-paper and marking-scheme tools used under real pressure, by students who will tell us what breaks.

MAR TO JUN 2027

The run-in and the exam

The only chance this year to see how the whole platform behaves across a full Leaving Cert season.

SEP 2027

A new cohort starts on a tested platform

Every tool shaped by a year of real student feedback, not a launch-week guess.

Three surfaces produced 41 messages and 16 shipped changes in four weeks. The full app has thirteen. More surface, more signal, more fixed before September.

Feedback on the stripped-back app cannot improve tools the students never see. Holding the full app back until 2027 means launching it untested on the cohort that matters.

The loop, the inbox and the deploy pipeline shown in this deck need no new build to run on the full app. They already do.

THE ASK

Roll out the full app to the pilot schools this year.

The loop is proven

41 messages, 16 changes live, a median of three days from message to fix.

The demand is theirs

Exam practice was the pilot cohort's own top feature request. It is already built.

The window is now

Mocks in January are the one real test before September 2027. The next cohort inherits whatever we learn.

nextstepuni · nextstepuniinfo@gmail.com · Every figure in this deck can be traced to the feedback inbox or the release log on request.